



Harden your Devices

Lock down devices that carry your entire life

An anonymous browser session cannot protect a phone that anyone can unlock. A separated identity can collapse when notifications appear on a shared laptop or an abandoned application keeps reading contacts and location. Your device is the foundation beneath every privacy tool you use. If that foundation leaks, the layers above it merely create an illusion of control.

Device hardening means reducing unnecessary access, closing obvious attack paths and preparing for loss or theft. It does not mean disabling every useful feature. The aim is proportionate protection: strong locks, current software, encrypted storage, restrained permissions and deliberate synchronisation.

Begin with the four foundations

First, the device must still receive operating-system and security

updates. Android lets users inspect the Android version, security update and Google Play system update from Settings, although the precise menu names and update availability depend on the manufacturer and device. Windows devices should also be kept on a supported release; free security fixes for Windows 10 ended on 14 October 2025, making an unsupported installation a poor foundation for sensitive work.

Second, the device needs a strong screen lock. Prefer a six-digit or longer PIN to a short, predictable code; use an alphanumeric password when the threat justifies the inconvenience. Biometrics make frequent unlocking convenient, but retain a strong PIN or password because it remains the underlying recovery credential.

Third, storage should be encrypted. Encryption protects data at rest when a locked device is lost, stolen or its drive is removed.